

VICTIM OF HUMAN APATHY
An injured black kite at a Wildlife SOS bird clinic in Delhi NCR

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

At a shelter run by the NGO Wildlife SOS in Garhi Harsaru, a hamlet on the outskirts of Gurugram, an Egyptian vulture awaits treatment for a fractured wing and pneumonia. A solemn-looking bird to begin with, which goes by the formal name of *Neophron percnopterus ginginianus* (the last derived from Gingee, a town in Tamil Nadu), the forlorn, yellow-billed creature in the cage is weighed by a burden even heavier—for, on his recovery depends the survival of the rest of its vulture brethren. The White-rumped vulture, Indian vulture and the Red-headed vulture have suffered long-term declines of 98 per cent, 95 per cent and 91 per cent, respectively. The culprit has been long known—the anti-inflammatory drug diclofenac, used commonly to treat livestock for a range of ailments. The consequences, however, prove fatal for the birds, who succumb to renal failure a day or two after feeding on cattle carcasses.

In another part of the country, 39-year-old Abhishek Das, a businessman from Kolkata and an avid birdwatcher, is up at dawn hoping to catch sight of the Wreathed hornbill (*Rhyticeros undulatus*), one of the nine varieties of hornbills found in India. Forever fascinated by the bird's red eye and yellow gular pouch, Das is in Namdapha National Park in Arunachal Pradesh to catch a glimpse of the bird before it disappears forever. Destruction of forest land has been a predominant factor in the diminishing of the species, also nicknamed 'farmer of the forest' for its astonishing seed dispersal skills, vital in forest regeneration. The bird has been classified as 'vulnerable' in IUCN's red list since 2018. The UK-based IUCN, or the



"There are several birds endemic to India, like the Floricans and Bustards, that could go extinct if we don't reverse their decline"

– VIVEK MENON *Founder trustee & executive director, Wildlife Trust of India*